

# FILM DOSSIER: GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY

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Phase 2 · Film #6 (Saga Film #14)

Status: ☒ DOSSIER COMPLETE (awaiting showrunner lock)

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## 1. IDENTITY

| Field                  | Entry                                                                        |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Film #                 | 14 of 29 (Phase 2, Film #6)                                                  |
| Phase                  | Phase 2                                                                      |
| Real title             | <i>GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY</i>                                               |
| Decoy / codename title | " <i>MIXTAPE</i> "                                                           |
| Release date           | Friday, August 1, 2014                                                       |
| Distributor            | Walt Disney Studios Motion Pictures                                          |
| Director               | James Gunn                                                                   |
| Rating / runtime       | PG-13 · 152 minutes                                                          |
| Genre + second genre   | Superhero action-adventure + <b>space opera</b> / <b>ragtag heist comedy</b> |

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## 2. OWNERSHIP

| Field                           | Entry                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Whose film / franchise is this? | <b>The Guardians ensemble</b> , led by <b>Chris Pratt</b> (Star-Lord). All of these roles have had only one real actor each, so no picks are needed. |

| Character                                                                     | Actor                                                                     | Age at release |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| <b>Peter Quill / Star-Lord</b>                                                | Chris Pratt                                                               | 35             |
| <b>Gamora</b>                                                                 | Zoe Saldña                                                                | 36             |
| <b>Drax the Destroyer</b>                                                     | Dave Bautista                                                             | 45             |
| <b>Rocket Raccoon</b>                                                         | Bradley Cooper ( <i>voice</i> ) / Sean Gunn ( <i>on-set performance</i> ) | 39 / 40        |
| <b>Groot</b>                                                                  | Vin Diesel ( <i>voice</i> )                                               | 47             |
| <b>Adam Warlock / The Magus</b>                                               | Will Poulter ( <i>both roles</i> )                                        | 21             |
| <b>Mantis</b>                                                                 | Pom Klementieff                                                           | 28             |
| <b>Nebula</b>                                                                 | Karen Gillan                                                              | 26             |
| <b>Thanos</b>                                                                 | Josh Brolin ( <i>on-set performance capture</i> )                         | 46             |
| <b>Death</b>                                                                  | Aubrey Plaza ( <i>see casting note</i> )                                  | 30             |
| <b>Taneleer Tivan, the Collector</b>                                          | Benicio del Toro                                                          | 47             |
| <b>Stan Lee</b> ( <i>cameo: a Xandarian chatting up a woman on Knowhere</i> ) | Stan Lee                                                                  | 91             |

*Casting note, applied to the whole saga: under the Casting Rules, Mistress Death is played by Aubrey Plaza, the only real actor to have played Marvel's Death. She has played the silent hooded woman since Iron Man (2008, age 23), and the earlier dossiers are updated to match.*

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### 3. SOURCE MATERIAL (EARTH-616)

| Field                    | Entry                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Primary comic(s) adapted | <i>Guardians of the Galaxy</i> vol. 2 #1–4 (2008), Dan Abnett & Andy Lanning: <b>the modern Guardians form</b> : Star-Lord, Gamora, Drax, Rocket, Groot, Adam Warlock and Mantis. <b>Jim Starlin's "Magus Saga"</b> , <i>Strange Tales</i> #178–181 & <i>Warlock</i> #9–11 (1975): <b>Adam Warlock vs. the Magus</b> , his evil future self, and the <b>Universal Church of Truth</b> , with <b>Thanos and Gamora</b> as Warlock's uneasy allies.                                                 |
| Supporting comics        | <i>Iron Man</i> #55 (1973, <b>Drax, created to kill Thanos</b> ) · <i>Strange Tales</i> #180 (1975, <b>Gamora</b> , Thanos's adopted daughter) · <i>Marvel Preview</i> #4 (1976, <b>Star-Lord</b> ) · <i>Incredible Hulk</i> #271 (1982, <b>Rocket Raccoon</b> ) · <i>Tales to Astonish</i> #13 (1960, <b>Groot</b> ) · <i>Avengers</i> #112 (1973, <b>Mantis</b> ) · <i>Avengers</i> #257 (1985, <b>Nebula</b> ) · <i>Fantastic Four</i> #66–67 (1967, " <b>Him," who becomes Adam Warlock</b> ) |
| Nerf check               | ✅ <b>Drax, built to kill Thanos, attacks him and loses.</b> On 616, Thanos is stronger. Warlock beats the Magus <b>with the Soul Gem</b> , at full cosmic power.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

#### 3A. COMIC ACCURACY REPORT

| Field                  | Entry                                                                                                            |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Overall accuracy score | <b>95%</b> . It combines the 2008 team formation with Starlin's 1975 Magus Saga. Every character comes from 616. |

##### Straight from the page:

- **Gamora is the last of the Zen-Whoberi. Thanos took her as a child** and made her "**the deadliest woman in the galaxy**" (*Strange Tales* #180).
- **Drax the Destroyer: Arthur Douglas**, an Earthman killed by Thanos, whose spirit was put into a new body by **Mentor and Kronos** for one purpose: **to kill Thanos** (*Iron Man* #55).
- **Star-Lord: Peter Quill**, a half-human boy whose mother was murdered by alien invaders. He grew up to be a **space-faring outlaw** (*Marvel Preview* #4).
- **Rocket** (a gun-toting raccoon from **Halfworld**) and **Groot** (a *Flora colossus*, "**I am Groot**").
- **Adam Warlock** carries **the Soul Gem on his forehead**. The **Magus** is **his own evil future self**, who rules the **Universal Church of Truth**. **Thanos helps Warlock** against the Magus **for his own reasons** (the Magus Saga).
- **Nebula** claims to be **Thanos's granddaughter** (616) and hates him and Gamora.
- **Mantis** is an empath and martial artist.

##### Changes and why:

| Change | Why |

|---|---|

| The 2008 team forms during the 1975 Magus Saga | It puts the Guardians and Thanos's family in the same story |

| Quill's age (35) | Matches Pratt; the 616 details are the same |

## POWERS & ABILITIES

| Character    | 616 powers & abilities                                                                                                                | Shown in this film                                                                         | Held back (why)                     | Match     |
|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-----------|
| Star-Lord    | Half-Spartax; expert pilot and marksman; element guns; a tactician                                                                    | All of it                                                                                  | His <b>Spartax</b> heritage (later) | ✓<br>100% |
| Gamora       | Enhanced by Thanos: <b>superhuman strength, speed and healing; the deadliest woman in the galaxy</b>                                  | Takes apart a squad of Church Blackguards alone                                            | –                                   | ✓<br>100% |
| Drax         | <b>Superhuman strength and durability; cosmic energy blasts from his hands; flight</b> ; built for one purpose ( <i>Iron Man</i> #55) | Flight, cosmic blasts, <b>going head to head with Thanos</b> (and losing)                  | –                                   | ✓<br>100% |
| Rocket       | Tactician; weapons genius; pilot                                                                                                      | All of it                                                                                  | –                                   | ✓<br>100% |
| Groot        | <b>Regrows from a twig</b> , grows at will, <b>tremendous strength</b> ; controls plants                                              | Wraps the team in a protective sphere of branches; regrows from a twig                     | –                                   | ✓<br>100% |
| Adam Warlock | <b>Cosmic energy manipulation</b> , flight, <b>the Soul Gem</b> (takes souls into itself), super strength, cocoon regeneration        | All of it; the Soul Gem <b>takes the Magus's soul into it</b>                              | –                                   | ✓<br>100% |
| The Magus    | Warlock's powers, <b>amplified</b> ; commands the Universal Church of Truth                                                           | A fight that splits a planet                                                               | –                                   | ✓<br>100% |
| Mantis       | <b>Empathy</b> , precognition, master martial artist                                                                                  | Senses Thanos's intentions (see below)                                                     | –                                   | ✓<br>100% |
| Nebula       | Cybernetic enhancements; expert fighter and pirate                                                                                    | Fights Gamora to a draw                                                                    | –                                   | ✓<br>100% |
| Thanos       | <b>Class-100+ strength</b> , near-invulnerable, cosmic energy blasts, <b>a genius beyond any mortal</b>                               | <b>Swats Drax aside with one hand</b> ; seen in the post-credit scene with <b>two Gems</b> | Everything else (Phase 3)           | ✓<br>100% |

## 4. STORY

| Field                | Entry                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Logline              | An Earth-born outlaw, a raccoon, a tree, a vengeful brute and the daughter of the Mad Titan have to save the galaxy from a god-man's evil future self, with Thanos watching the whole time. |
| Theme                | <b>Family you choose.</b> Every Guardian has lost a family, and they find one in each other.                                                                                                |
| Villain / antagonist | <b>The Magus</b> and the <b>Universal Church of Truth</b> (main); <b>Nebula</b> ; <b>Thanos</b> (in the shadows)                                                                            |

### What the movie is about

#### ACT ONE: THE BARGAIN

- **1988, Missouri:** young Peter Quill watches **alien invaders kill his mother**. He's taken into space.
- **Present day (Monday, May 19, 2014): Star-Lord**, an outlaw, steals a relic from a temple, and it turns out to be the location of **Adam Warlock's cocoon**.
- Every bounty hunter in the galaxy comes after him: **Rocket and Groot**, and **Gamora**, who has been sent by **Thanos**.
- **Drax** hears the name "Thanos" in a Knowhere bar and charges.
- The four of them, and eventually **Mantis**, end up running for their lives together.

#### ACT TWO: WARLOCK

- The cocoon opens, and **Adam Warlock** comes out with a **green Gem burning on his brow**.
- Warlock warns them about the **Universal Church of Truth**, which is led by **the Magus**, his own future self and a tyrant who worships himself.
- The Church hunts the team. **Nebula**, the Magus's hired pirate, fights Gamora.
- **Thanos appears**. He offers **an alliance** against the Magus. Drax attacks him on sight, and **Thanos swats him aside with one hand**.
- **Mantis**, touching Thanos's mind: *"He's in love. And it's the most frightening thing I've ever felt."*

#### ACT THREE: GUARDIANS

- The final assault on the Church's cathedral world, with Thanos's forces fighting alongside the heroes.
  - **Warlock vs. the Magus**. Warlock uses **the Soul Gem on his own future**. The Magus is **drawn into the Gem**, screaming.
  - **Thanos** asks for the **Soul Gem**. Warlock refuses. Thanos smiles: *"In time, Warlock."* and leaves.
  - Gamora doesn't go with him. **She stays**.
  - Quill looks at the six of them: *"What do we call ourselves?"* Rocket: *"Something stupid, probably."* Quill: *"The Guardians of the Galaxy."*
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## 5. MCU TIMELINE PLACEMENT

| Field                   | Entry                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| When it's set           | 1988 (prologue) · <b>Monday, May 19, 2014</b> → <b>Saturday, July 12, 2014</b> (Earth dates). The post-credit scene takes place <b>the same week</b> .                                                                                                                                      |
| Where it's set          | <b>Missouri, 1988</b> · <b>Knowhere</b> (a mining colony inside the severed head of a Celestial) · <b>the Collector's museum</b> (rebuilt) · <b>the Universal Church's cathedral world</b> · <b>deep space</b> (filmed on practical sets at Shepperton Studios, and in Iceland and Morocco) |
| Relative to other films | <b>Three months after <i>The Amazing Spider-Man</i></b> . Quill's Walkman mixtape is the only piece of Earth he has left.                                                                                                                                                                   |

## 6. WORLD-BUILDING

### The film's own world

- **The Guardians**, **Knowhere**, the **Universal Church of Truth**, the **Magus**.
- **Adam Warlock** and **the Soul Gem**.
- **Thanos's family**: Gamora, Nebula, and Drax, his living curse.

### World-building for the wider MCU

| Seed                           | How it appears                                                                     | Payoff                                                                 |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The Soul Gem is in play</b> | Warlock wears it                                                                   | <b><i>The Infinity Gauntlet</i></b> (on 616, Warlock is central to it) |
| <b>Earth is known</b>          | Quill mentions "a planet with Avengers now."<br>Rocket: " <i>Sounds made up.</i> " | Phase 3 crossover                                                      |
| <b>The Kree</b>                | A Kree warship passes by in the background                                         | Captain Marvel (Phase 3)                                               |

### Setting up the Big Bad

| Seed                     | How it appears                                | What it means                      |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| <b>Thanos, in person</b> | His first full scenes and dialogue in the MCU | <b>He's real, and he's here.</b>   |
| "He's in love."          | Mantis reads his mind                         | <b>Death is the reason.</b>        |
| <b>The Soul Gem</b>      | Warlock refuses him: " <i>In time.</i> "      | Thanos <b>will</b> come for it.    |
| <b>Two Gems</b>          | The post-credit scene                         | The <b>Thanos Quest</b> continues. |

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## 7. POST-CREDIT SCENES

| Field                  | Entry                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mid-credit scene       | ✓ "DANCE." On the Guardians' ship, a tiny sapling <b>Groot</b> , regrowing in a pot, dances to Quill's mixtape whenever Drax isn't looking. Drax is looking.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Post-credit scene      | ✓ "THE CHAMPION." An arena world. The <b>Champion of the Universe</b> , an Elder, huge and scarred, lies beaten in the sand of his own arena. <b>Thanos</b> stands over him and pulls a <b>second Gem</b> from the Champion's belt. It sets into the <b>Gauntlet</b> with a sound like thunder.<br>At the arena gate, <b>Death</b> (Aubrey Plaza) watches.<br><b>THANOS:</b> <i>"Two, my love."</i><br>She turns and walks away. <b>CUT TO BLACK. "THE GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY WILL RETURN."</b> |
| Secret shoot codenames | Mid-credit: " <b>GARDENING.</b> " Post-credit: " <b>WRESTLEMANIA.</b> "                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

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## CHECKLIST

- [x] Comic(s) adapted · [x] Comic Accuracy Report + powers · [x] Real and decoy titles · [x] What it's about · [x] Villain · [x] Post-credit scenes · [x] The film's own world-building · [x] MCU world-building · [x] Big Bad setup · [x] Whose franchise · [x] When and where in the timeline